

few other officers with similar disabilities competed in the golf event at the World Para Sports Games in Bengaluru.

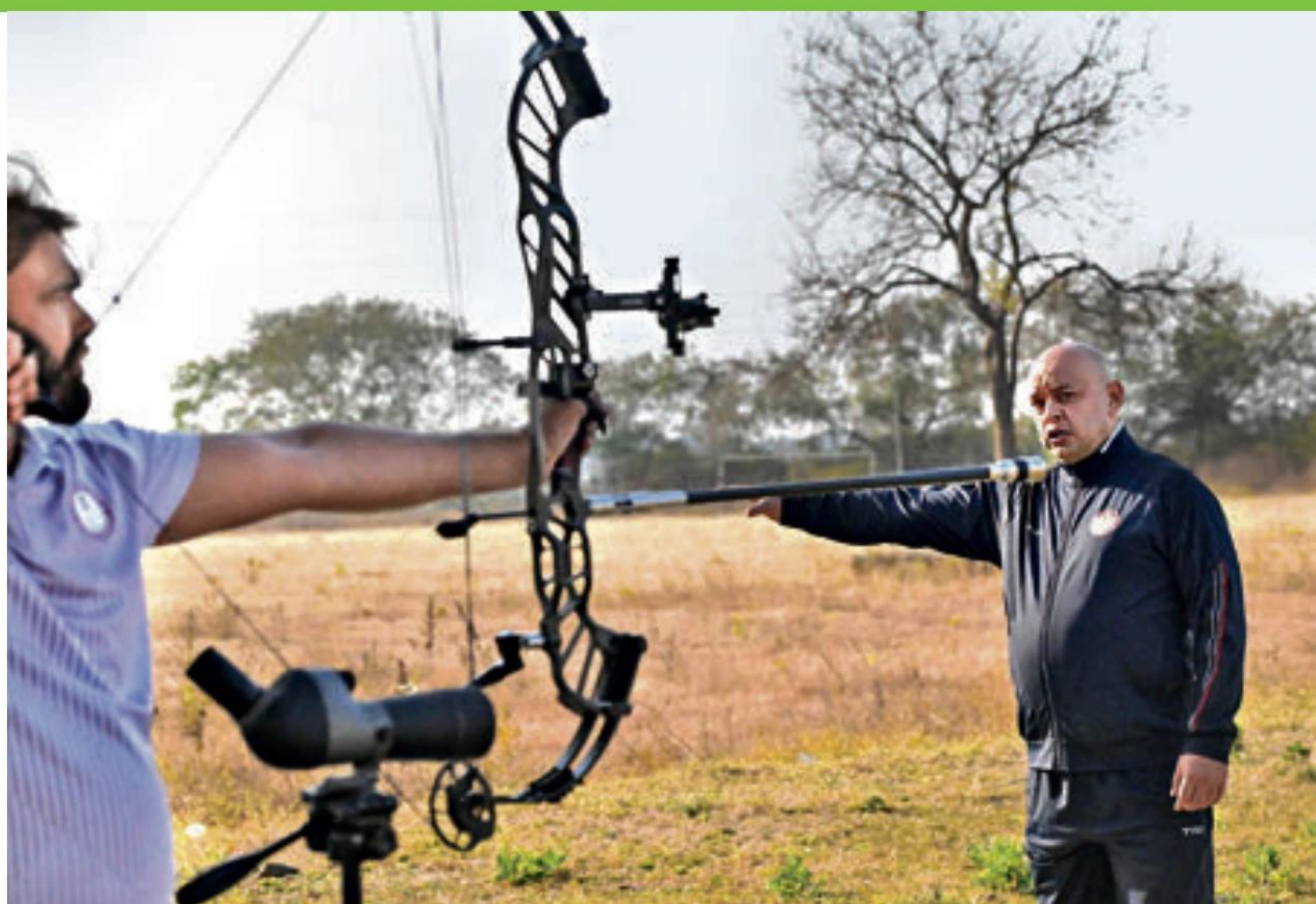
"While I was there, I realised that there were so many people with disabilities in the Army, but apart from a few of us, there didn't seem to be a single Army man in Team India. That's when I decided I should do something about it," he says.

Dutta approached the Army headquarters with the idea of creating a system through which injured soldiers could compete in para sports as representatives of the armed forces. It was easier said than done. "Although the policy is that soldiers injured during service are retained in the Army, there was no procedure to create a sports unit from among them. One reason was that Army policy also discouraged disabled soldiers from participating in competitive sports that could worsen their injuries," he explains.

Change was slow. While awaiting official approval, Dutta did what he could. He visited the Artificial Limb Centre (ALC) in Pune and spoke to injured soldiers about joining a sports programme. Someswararao was among the earliest recruits. "I was 24 when I lost my leg to a mine blast. I came to the ALC and met Col Dutta for the first time. He would buy us vada pav and samosas from the canteen while trying to convince us about his mission. He came four or five times, and finally, when he asked if anyone wanted to try sports, I raised my hand," Someswararao, now 35, recalls.

He was not alone. Future Paralympic medallist Hokato Sema, who was at the ALC for a prosthetic refitting, joined too, as did Soman Rana, a former national-level boxer.

Even so, early numbers were thin. In 2015, when Dutta decided to field a team at the National Para Athletics Championships, he was short of athletes. "The team included Col Dutta himself, but we still only had nine members. That's when he put my name in the team. He got me a running blade, and two days later, I was competing at the nationals. It was a miracle I even finished the race



Guided purpose: Lt Col Nitten Mehta, himself injured in service, leads a unit built to turn wounded soldiers into elite para athletes.

because my hands, my good leg and my blade were all moving differently. There was no coordination after just one day of practice," Someswararao laughs.

That first competition came with other challenges. "We weren't formally recognised then, so we had no official kit. I didn't want the men competing in different colours. I wanted them to feel like one unit.

Brigadier Satish, who headed the ALC, and I pooled our money to get a kit made," says Dutta.

Strong-minded recruits

In 2017, the Node received formal recognition from the Army. Since then, both numbers and resources have grown. "In the beginning, we had very little. A couple of coaches managed everything," says Mehta.



A career rebuilt: Now a shot putter in para athletics, Soman Rana is among the international medallists produced by the Army Paralympic Node.